STARS ON OUR MIND

Nothing dislodges Big B, but SRK sees the biggest jump in popularity in six months and Deepika Padukone is back at No. 1. **OTT stars shine bright too, playing relatable characters** with thespian panache

By **SUHANI SINGH**



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The brightest stars may flicker but they finally find their shine. In the past few years, the holy troika of Khans—Aamir, Shah Rukh and Salman—lost a bit of their lustre. Salman's dominance at the box office wavered; Aamir, the most private and pickiest of the lot, saw his fortunes swing; and Shah Rukh, after two back-to-back duds—*Jab Harry Met Sejal* and *Zero*—took a sabbatical and laid low, his appearance limited to occasional AMA (ask me anything) sessions on Twitter. But order is restored in the latest edition of INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation poll. The Badshah a.k.a. Shah Rukh is back in business, pushing Akshay Kumar down to third, simply on the basis of announcing that he has three releases in 2023—YRF's *Pathan*, Atlee's *Jawan* and Rajkumar Hirani's *Dunki*. Audiences, it appears, are keen to see these films. If Shah Rukh is the biggest riser, the legendary Amitabh Bachchan sees his popularity dip by a few points but not enough to dethrone him from pole position. Salman 'Bhai' rounds off the top five.

Among actresses, Deepika Padukone reclaims the throne from Katrina Kaif on the back of her affecting performance in *Gehraiyaan*, which had a direct-to-digital release. Another powerhouse performer of 2022, Alia Bhatt, ascended to No. 3. She started the year with a commanding act in *Gangubai Kathiawadi* and then made headlines for tying the knot

Q. Who is the No. 1 hero in the country?



SHAH RUKH KHAN
15%
[5%]



AKSHAY KUMAR
10%
[12%]



RAJINIKANTH
9%
[4%]



SALMAN KHAN
7%
[7%]